

ABHYAS GALLI

Mumbai

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"Ours was a joint family and the house was just 10x10 ft, which made it difficult for me to study. So I used to study at abhyas galli"

— D.V. PAWAR, Principal, Kirti M. Doongursee College of Arts, Science and Commerce

says he goes to 'abhyas galli' as it lets him study with a group and take the help of his peers.

Successive governments have taken steps to make the place comfortable for students. Shiv Sena leader and former state environment minister Aaditya Thackeray, who represents Worli in the state legislative assembly, initiated the beautification of the lane through his MLA funds. The lane has a water cooler and a double-storeyed toilet for students. The road has been concretised, and the footpath on which the youngsters sit has been refurbished. A network of CCTV cameras is also in place. There's enough lighting, thanks to Halogen lamps, and platforms have been built for students to sit and study. The walls on the road now have graffiti that details career options after Class 12, and QR codes have been put up for students to provide information that may help them choose among subjects like law, chartered accountancy, armed forces or medicine. Patil adds that during the exam season, they distributed tea for free at night.

However, a few niggling problems remain. For instance, one side of the road is dotted with vehicles, including goods transport and heavy vehicles, which are parked illegally. Patil complains that this leads to an accumulation of garbage. Couples also use the space behind the vehicles to snatch a few quiet moments, as do some drunkards and those involved in substance abuse. "*Daas pan chavtat, aani mansa pan* [Mosquitoes trouble us, and so do some people]," says Rupali Salve, a Mahalaxmi resident who comes here to study for her higher secondary exam. She usually lights a mosquito repellent coil near her. But it's unruly couples, drunkards, drug addicts and people shooting Instagram videos that she finds more irksome. "We have to spend our time asking them to behave themselves," she complains, pointing to how the platforms built for the students are often misused by these people. Regular police patrols may help reduce such incidents, says Salve. Akshay Pawar, a third-year student of commerce, has another suggestion: the lane should be closed to traffic in the evenings so that students can study in peace.

The administration would do well to take note of such complaints. Over the years, the 'abhyas galli' has been etched in Mumbai's history and has shaped the careers of thousands of students. It remains yet another symbol of grit and perseverance in the City of Dreams. ■